US nuclear war plans called for U-2s to fly into Soviet air space and locate Soviet long-range bombers. By then, US attack orders would have been issued, InterContinental Ballistic Missiles (ICBMs) and Submarine Launched Ballistic Missiles (SLBMs) would be preparing to launch, and SAC's strategic bombers would be heading into Soviet air space. A nuclear first strike would be getting under way. If Soviet leaders thought they were about to be attacked, they would be faced with the decision whether to 'use or lose' their ICBMs. It was also possible that the Soviets could have mistaken the U-2 for a SAC bomber heading to its target.

McNamara understood the logic of the situation. When, some years later, he learned from USAF intelligence that the Soviets were hardening their ICBM silos, he expressed satisfaction rather than anxiety – the more survivable Soviet retaliatory forces, the less their need 'to use them or lose them' (he was nevertheless nearly lynched, as he put it, when word of his reaction leaked out).[58] On 27 October McNamara was concerned that Moscow might indeed misinterpret the U-2's mission to be 'pre-SIOP reconnaissance'. In such circumstances, US pre-emption of Soviet pre-emption was certainly conceivable (though there is no evidence of any such consideration). Khrushchev appears to have been told by his generals that the U-2 could be on a reconnaissance mission ahead of a US first strike.[59] According to Khrushchev's chief foreign policy adviser, Oleg Troyanovsky, this was the tensest moment of the crisis for the Soviet leader and his officials.[60]

The straying U-2 was dubbed by Roger Hilsman, Director of Intelligence and Research at the State Department, as the 'Strangelove incident.'[61] Hilsman recounts how he ran to give the President details, 'out of breath and shaky from over thirty hours without sleep'. The President gave a 'short ironic laugh' and responded with a naval colloquialism: 'There's always some sonofabitch who doesn't get the word.' Robert McNamara's reaction was less ironic. According to the Director of Plans on the Air Staff, General David Burchinal, the Defense Secretary, 'turned absolutely white and yelled hysterically, "This means war with the Soviet Union. The President must get on the hotline to Moscow." And he ran out of the meeting in a frenzy.'[62] There is no corroboration of Burchinal's account and McNamara denied the